1. Employment and Attendance

Northstar Digital Systems is a fictional software organization used solely as a dRAGn demonstration corpus. This handbook is intentionally detailed so that a retrieval system must distinguish similar rules, numerical thresholds, exceptions, and policy scope.

Policy rules

- Full-time employees follow their team schedule; part-time employees follow the schedule in their employment letter.
- Contractors are governed by their statement of work and contractor access agreement.
- Probation normally lasts six months and requires confirmation from the manager and People Operations.
- The standard collaboration window is 10:00 AM to 4:00 PM local time.
- Unexpected absence should be communicated before the working day starts whenever reasonably possible.
- Repeated unexplained absence may trigger an attendance review; one late arrival does not automatically trigger disciplinary action.

Operational interpretation

The collaboration window is intended to make cross-team work predictable rather than to prescribe identical start and end times for every employee. A team may document a different schedule when customer coverage, operations, or project requirements justify it.

Attendance decisions should consider the documented schedule, approved leave, manager communication, and any applicable accommodation. An informal message from a colleague does not itself create a new attendance policy.

Records and controls

- Managers should retain approved schedule exceptions and probation decisions in the appropriate HR system.
- Employees should keep contact details current so urgent operational communication can reach them.
- Contractor access records must align with the end date of the statement of work.

Common questions

- Does probation end automatically after six months? No. Confirmation is required.
- Can a team define different core hours? Yes, when documented.
- Does one late arrival automatically cause disciplinary action? No.

Operational scenario

A new employee joins a team whose employment letter specifies a different working pattern from the general handbook. The employee should follow the individual employment letter for that circumstance while still following general security, conduct, and reporting requirements. A manager should not create a permanent exception through an informal chat message. If the schedule needs to change for the whole team, the change should be documented so that employees have a clear reference point.

Interpretation and operational notes

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Operational decisions should preserve the distinction between entitlement, approval, and compliance. Having a leave balance does not mean every requested date is approved. Being eligible for remote work does not remove mandatory onsite requirements. Having access to an AI tool does not authorize confidential data to be entered into it. Similarly, having a reimbursement receipt does not make a personal expense a business expense. The safest interpretation is therefore to retrieve the rule and its surrounding condition, rather than returning a number without the qualifying language.

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2. Leave and Time Off

Annual leave entitlement

Employees receive 18 days of annual leave per calendar year. Employees joining after 30 June receive a prorated balance. Leave is intended to provide planned time away from work, so employees should submit requests before making non-refundable travel commitments.

- Requests exceeding three consecutive working days should normally be submitted at least seven calendar days in advance.
- Up to 12 unused annual-leave days may be carried forward. Amounts above the carry-forward limit normally expire at year end.

Sick leave

- Employees receive 12 sick days per calendar year.
- A medical certificate may be requested for an absence longer than three consecutive working days.

Parental leave

- Eligible primary caregivers receive 20 weeks of paid parental leave.
- Eligible secondary caregivers receive 4 weeks of paid parental leave.

Parental leave should normally begin within six months of the qualifying event unless People Operations approves a later start.

Examples and controls

An employee with 15 unused annual-leave days at year end would normally carry forward 12 and lose the remaining 3, subject to any applicable local rule or approved exception. A five-day planned vacation should normally be requested at least seven calendar days in advance.

Leave approval is separate from entitlement. Having an available balance does not mean the request is automatically approved; staffing, project commitments, and required notice may be considered.

Operational scenario

An employee requests five consecutive working days of annual leave and has enough balance available. The manager should check the notice requirement, team coverage, and any operational constraints before approving the dates. The available balance answers whether the employee has entitlement; it does not answer whether the requested dates can be approved. At year end, only up to 12 unused annual-leave days normally carry forward, so an employee with 15 unused days should not assume all 15 remain available in the next calendar year.

Interpretation and operational notes

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3. Remote and Hybrid Work

Standard remote arrangement

- Eligible employees may work remotely up to three days per week when the role and team permit it.
- Remote work does not replace mandatory onsite events, customer meetings, security-sensitive sessions, or approved workshops.
- Remote employees must use company-approved authentication, endpoint protection, and network security controls.
- Company equipment should not be left unattended in publicly accessible locations.

Temporary exceptions

- Managers may approve temporary full-remote arrangements for up to 30 calendar days for documented circumstances.
- Exceptions longer than 30 calendar days require People Operations approval and a documented review date.

Operational scenarios

A developer who normally works remotely three days each week may still be required to attend a quarterly security workshop onsite. The remote-work arrangement does not override a mandatory event.

A temporary full-remote approval for 20 calendar days can be handled by the manager when the documented circumstances qualify. A 45-day arrangement requires the additional People Operations approval.

Security expectations

- Employees must lock devices when unattended and avoid using public computers for company systems.
- Sensitive conversations should not be conducted where unauthorized people can overhear them.

Operational scenario

An eligible employee normally works remotely three days each week but is asked to attend an onsite security review. The onsite requirement takes precedence because the remote arrangement does not override mandatory events. A separate employee who needs 20 consecutive days of full remote work may receive a manager-approved temporary exception when the circumstances qualify. A 45-day exception needs the additional People Operations approval described in the handbook.

Interpretation and operational notes

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4. Compensation, Benefits and Expenses

Payroll

- Salary is paid monthly on the last working day.
- If the scheduled payment day is a company holiday, payment is normally made on the preceding working day.

Performance reviews

- Performance reviews occur twice each year.
- A performance review does not guarantee a salary increase, promotion, or bonus.

Health benefit eligibility

- Employees normally become eligible for the company health plan after 30 days of continuous employment unless the offer letter states otherwise.

Expense rules

- Business expenses should normally be submitted within 30 calendar days.
- Receipts are required for individual expenses above ₹1,500. A lost receipt requires a written declaration and manager approval.
- Personal entertainment, traffic fines, minibar charges, and expenses for non-business companions are not reimbursable.

Scenario

If an employee spends ₹1,200 on a business meal, the receipt should be retained as required by the finance process even though the individual expense is below the ₹1,500 threshold. If a ₹2,000 business expense has no receipt, the employee should use the documented lost-receipt procedure rather than simply omitting the expense.

Controls

- Expense reports should identify the business purpose and project or cost center when required.
- Managers should review expenses for business relevance before approval.

Operational scenario

An employee submits a ₹2,000 business expense without the original receipt. The employee should use the documented lost-receipt declaration process and obtain the required approval instead of treating the expense as automatically reimbursable. A separate ₹1,200 business meal is below the ₹1,500 receipt threshold, but the employee should still retain whatever supporting evidence the finance workflow requires. The reimbursement decision depends on business purpose, policy limits, timing, and approval.

Interpretation and operational notes

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5. Security and Acceptable Use

Identity and credentials

- Corporate credentials must never be shared.
- Multi-factor authentication is mandatory for systems that support it.
- Suspected phishing, credential compromise, accidental disclosure, or unauthorized access must be reported within one hour of discovery.

Data handling

- Confidential customer data must not be copied into public AI tools, personal email, unmanaged cloud storage, or personal repositories.
- USB storage may be used only when encrypted and approved by IT Security.

Generative AI

Public generative AI may be used for non-confidential drafting, brainstorming, public-material summarization, and generic examples. Customer secrets, credentials, personal data, confidential source code, security findings, and unreleased financial information must not be entered into public AI systems.

Approved internal AI tools may be used for confidential workloads only when the tool is authorized for the relevant classification. Generated code remains subject to normal review, testing, licensing, and security controls.

Incident scenario

If an employee accidentally pastes a customer identifier into a public AI assistant, the correct response is not to hide the incident. The employee should report the accidental disclosure to Security within one hour and follow the incident-response instructions.

Operational scenario

An employee accidentally pastes confidential customer information into a public AI assistant. The correct response is to report the accidental disclosure to Security within one hour and follow the incident-response process. Deleting the conversation locally does not replace reporting. The same policy also prohibits sharing credentials and requires multi-factor authentication where supported. Generated code from an approved AI tool remains subject to normal review, testing, licensing, and security controls.

Interpretation and operational notes

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6. Performance, Conduct and Workplace Behavior

Performance management

- Managers should address concerns using specific examples, clear expectations, and an improvement plan where appropriate.
- Employees should communicate blockers early rather than allowing missed commitments to remain unexplained.
- A performance review is an assessment process and does not itself guarantee compensation changes.

Workplace behavior

- Respectful communication is expected across offices, remote channels, customer interactions, and written communication.
- Harassment, discrimination, threats, and deliberate intimidation are prohibited.
- Retaliation against a person raising a good-faith concern is prohibited.

Corrective action

Depending on severity, corrective action may include coaching, written warning, final warning, suspension, or termination. Serious misconduct may bypass progressive steps where permitted by applicable law and company policy.

Investigation responsibilities

- Employees may be asked to preserve relevant records and cooperate with an internal investigation.
- Managers should avoid promising a particular disciplinary outcome before the facts are reviewed.

Operational scenario

A manager has concerns about an employee missing documented goals. The manager should use specific examples, explain the expected outcome, and communicate a clear improvement path rather than relying on vague criticism. If the issue continues, corrective action may progress through coaching or written warnings depending on severity. Serious misconduct can require a different process. A good-faith workplace concern must be handled without retaliation against the person who raised it.

Interpretation and operational notes

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7. Travel and Business Expenses

Approval and transportation

- Domestic business travel requires manager approval before booking unless the trip is an emergency customer escalation.
- Economy airfare is the default for flights under six hours.
- Premium-cabin travel requires executive approval.

Accommodation and meals

- Hotel reimbursement is capped at ₹7,500 per night excluding taxes unless a city-specific exception is published.
- Meal reimbursement is capped at ₹1,200 per day while traveling on company business.
- Leisure extensions and expenses for non-business companions are not reimbursable.

Scenario analysis

A hotel room priced at ₹7,200 before taxes is within the standard nightly cap. A ₹9,000 room requires an applicable exception or additional approval; the employee should not assume the difference will be reimbursed.

A premium flight on a four-hour route is not automatically reimbursable because the employee prefers it. Executive approval is required.

Records

- Travel claims should contain the business purpose, dates, receipts, and required approval evidence.
- Employees should retain supporting records according to finance procedures.

Operational scenario

An employee books a ₹9,000 hotel room for a domestic business trip where the normal hotel cap is ₹7,500 per night excluding taxes. The employee should identify whether a documented city-specific exception applies or obtain the required approval. The higher price is not automatically reimbursable because the trip itself is business-related. The same principle applies to premium-cabin airfare: executive approval is required rather than assumed.

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8. Equipment and Information Management

Company assets

- Employees are responsible for laptops, access cards, security tokens, and other assigned assets.
- Lost or stolen equipment must be reported to IT within four hours of discovery.
- Employees leaving the company must return assigned equipment by the final working day unless an exception is approved.
- Company equipment must not be sold, loaned to unauthorized people, or used to store unrelated restricted material.

Information classification

- Public information may be shared externally.
- Internal information is intended for employees and approved contractors and should not normally be shared outside the organization.
- Confidential information requires controlled access.
- Restricted information requires explicit authorization and additional security controls.

Examples

Published website content is normally Public. Team procedures are normally Internal. Customer contracts and source code are normally Confidential. Credentials, encryption keys, and highly sensitive security records are normally Restricted.

Records

- Business records should be stored in approved company systems rather than personal accounts.
- Employees should follow retention and deletion instructions for the relevant system.

Operational scenario

A company laptop is lost while an employee is traveling. The employee should report the loss to IT within four hours of discovery so access and device-protection controls can be activated. The employee should not wait until returning to the office. Information classification also matters: Public, Internal, Confidential, and Restricted information require progressively stronger controls. Business records should remain in approved company systems rather than personal accounts.

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9. Leave, Security and Expense Scenarios

Scenario A: planned leave

An employee wants a five-working-day vacation beginning next month. The request should normally be submitted at least seven calendar days before the leave period. Approval depends on operational circumstances and available entitlement.

Scenario B: remote exception

An employee needs to work fully remotely for 20 calendar days due to a documented temporary circumstance. A manager may approve the arrangement within the 30-day exception limit. A longer arrangement needs People Operations approval and a review date.

Scenario C: suspected phishing

An employee clicks a suspicious link and enters a corporate password. The incident should be reported to Security within one hour. The employee should follow credential-reset and incident-response instructions rather than continuing to use the potentially compromised password.

Scenario D: expense

A ₹2,400 business expense has no receipt because the original was lost. The employee should use the written declaration process and obtain manager approval rather than treating the expense as automatically reimbursable.

Key thresholds

- Annual leave: 18 days.
- Carry-forward limit: 12 days.
- Sick leave: 12 days.
- Security incident reporting: within 1 hour.
- Remote exception without extended approval: up to 30 days.

Operational scenario

Consider three separate cases: a five-day vacation, a 20-day temporary remote exception, and a suspected credential compromise. The vacation requires normal leave approval and notice; the remote exception can be handled at manager level when it stays within the 30-day limit; the credential incident has the highest urgency and should be reported within one hour. These examples show why policy questions should be answered from the exact rule and its condition rather than from a generic summary.

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10. Frequently Asked Questions and Quick Reference

Leave

- How much annual leave is provided? 18 days per calendar year.
- How much can normally be carried forward? 12 days.
- How much sick leave is provided? 12 days.

Remote work

- How many remote days are normally permitted? Up to three per week when eligible.
- How long can a manager approve a temporary full-remote exception? Up to 30 calendar days.

Security

- How quickly should suspected credential compromise be reported? Within one hour.
- Can customer data be entered into a public AI tool? No.

Expenses

- What receipt threshold applies? Receipts are required above ₹1,500.
- What is the standard hotel cap? ₹7,500 per night excluding taxes.
- What is the standard meal cap? ₹1,200 per day.

This handbook is synthetic and intended only as a demonstration corpus for dRAGn.

Operational scenario

The quick-reference values are useful for checking answers but should not be treated as isolated facts. Annual leave is 18 days, sick leave is 12 days, carry-forward is normally capped at 12 days, remote work is normally up to three days per week, and the standard temporary full-remote exception is up to 30 days. Expense receipts are required above ₹1,500, the standard hotel cap is ₹7,500 per night, and meal reimbursement is capped at ₹1,200 per day.

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